

Dates, deadlines, and durations

Learner workbook

Distinguish a deadline from a continuing period.

Understand the distinction

Use on with a date, in with a month or year, and at with an exact time. Write the month name when a numeric date might be ambiguous across countries: 6 September 2026.

By Friday means no later than Friday. Until Friday means continuing up to Friday. Since identifies a starting point; for gives a duration. A deadline may need a time and time zone to be clear.

Compare the patterns

DEADLINE

Send the form by Friday at noon.

Friday at noon is the latest time.

CONTINUATION

The office is closed until Friday.

The closed state continues up to Friday.

DURATION

I have lived here for two years.

Two years measures the period.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. The appointment is ___ 6 September.

2. Which means no later than: by Friday / until Friday?

3. Complete: I have worked here ___ 2024.

Use it in your own life

Write a clear deadline with a date and a time.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. on

Use on with a particular date.

2. by Friday

Until describes a continuing action or state.

3. since

The year is a starting point.

One possible response

Please reply by 10 September at 3 p.m. New York time.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-15.html